

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT SESSION

Engaging Canvas Announcements with HTML + AI

A practical, field-tested workflow for turning plain-text course announcements into polished, branded, accessible messages your students actually read — using an AI assistant to write the HTML for you.

Why Bother? The Case for Designed Announcements

A default Canvas announcement is a wall of plain text. It works, but it competes with every other notification in a student's day. A designed announcement — with a branded header, clear sections for what's happening each day, a resource list, and a visible way to reach you — does three things a plain post can't:

- **Creates visual hierarchy.** Students can scan and find what matters (this week's topics, deadlines, exam alerts) in seconds.
- **Builds course identity.** Consistent colors and structure week after week signal professionalism and make announcements instantly recognizable as *yours*.
- **Lowens barriers to contact.** A prominent “Email Me” button and an office-hours block make reaching out feel invited, not intimidating.

The catch: hand-writing styled HTML is slow, and Canvas is picky about which HTML it accepts. That's where AI comes in. You describe the announcement in plain English; the AI writes Canvas-safe HTML; you paste it in, review, and post. After the first one, you save it as a template and each following week takes minutes.

The Workflow at a Glance

1. **Describe** the announcement to your AI assistant in plain language: course, audience, tone, what's happening this week.
2. **Constrain** the AI up front with the Canvas-safe rules (Section 3) so the code survives pasting.
3. **Review & iterate.** Look at the preview, react honestly (“that wording is corny,” “make Day One and Day Two subheaders”), and ask for options when unsure.
4. **Paste** into Canvas's HTML editor and save (Section 4).
5. **Verify** in Student View: styling intact, links work, images load, dates correct.
6. **Templatize.** Ask the AI to turn the final version into an annotated, reusable template with placeholders (Section 7).

1. Talking to the AI: What to Put in Your Prompt

The quality of the announcement tracks the quality of the brief. You don't need to know HTML — you need to know your course. Give the AI the same information you'd give a very capable TA:

- **Course & institution:** name, number, modality (online / in-person), and your school's brand colors if you want them (e.g., navy and orange).
- **Occasion:** weekly update, exam reminder, welcome-back, holiday notice. Special occasions can deliberately break from your weekly template so they stand out.
- **Content:** week number, chapters/sections covered, day-by-day plan, deadlines, resources to link, office hours.
- **Tone:** warm and encouraging, energetic, professional and concise — say it explicitly; the AI will match it.
- **Personality:** details like “statistics is a personal favorite of mine” give the AI something genuine to write around instead of generic filler.

Example prompt

I'm creating a weekly announcement for a purely online Finite Mathematics course. Students just returned from Spring Break -- welcome them back warmly. This week we start Chapter 11 (statistics -- a personal favorite of mine!) and cover three sections: 11.1, 11.2, 11.3. Encourage them to keep pace so we don't fall behind. Remind them they can always email me. Use my university's navy and red colors. Warm and encouraging tone. Output: HTML I can paste into Canvas.

TIP If the AI asks clarifying questions (format? colors? tone?), answer them — a 30-second exchange up front beats three rounds of revision later. And when the AI suggests something you don't understand, just ask *why*. “Why does the file type of each resource matter?” is a perfectly good message, and the answer (accessibility and expectation-setting) may change your decision.

2. The #1 Pitfall: Canvas Strips Your Code

This is the wall everyone hits first. An AI's default HTML output is a full web page: a `<style>` block of CSS, Google Fonts imports, maybe JavaScript. It looks beautiful in a browser preview — then you paste it into Canvas, hit Save, and the styling vanishes. Canvas's Rich Content Editor sanitizes pasted HTML and silently removes anything on the left side of this table:

Canvas removes on save	Use instead
<code><style></code> blocks and CSS classes	Inline styles on every element: <code>style="color:#12294B;font-size:15px;"</code>
External fonts (Google Fonts <code><link></code> / <code>@import</code>)	System fonts: Georgia, serif or Arial, sans-serif
<code><script></code> tags / any JavaScript	Static HTML only — no interactivity
<code><html></code> , <code><head></code> , <code><body></code> wrappers	A content fragment — one outer <code><div></code> is fine

CSS variables <code>var(--x)</code> , <code>:hover</code> / pseudo-classes, <code>@media</code> queries	Hard-coded values; static styling; flexible layouts via <code>flex-wrap</code> or <code>grid auto-fit</code>
Sub-pixel values (<code>0.5px</code> borders)	Whole pixels (<code>1px</code>)

The fix: tell the AI the rules before it writes anything

Paste this constraint block at the start of any new AI conversation about Canvas content. It converts hours of troubleshooting into zero:

```
Before we build this, hard constraints for Canvas's editor: when
Canvas saves content it strips <style> blocks, external font imports,
<script> tags, and <html>/<head>/<body> wrappers. Only inline
style="..." attributes on individual elements survive. So:
1. No <style> block -- every rule goes inline on the element itself.
2. No external fonts -- use system stacks (Georgia,serif or
   Arial,sans-serif).
3. No CSS variables -- hardcode real values on each element.
4. No :hover / pseudo-classes -- static styling only.
5. No @media queries -- for mobile-friendly layouts use
   display:flex;flex-wrap:wrap or grid repeat(auto-fit,minmax(...)).
6. No JavaScript -- everything static.
7. No page wrapper -- output a content fragment; one outer <div> max.
8. Whole-pixel values only (no 0.5px borders).
Give me the result as a single HTML fragment I can paste into the
Canvas HTML editor.
```

WATCH OUT If you already have a broken (class-based) announcement, don't rebuild by hand — paste it back to the AI and say “convert everything to inline styles per the constraints above.” The design survives; only the plumbing changes.

3. Getting the Code into Canvas

1. In your course, go to **Announcements** → + **Announcement** (the same steps work for Pages).
2. In the Rich Content Editor toolbar, click the `</>` icon (bottom-right) to switch to the **HTML editor**.
3. **Paste the entire HTML fragment** from the AI.
4. Click `</>` again to return to the visual editor — you should see the styled announcement render.
5. Fill in anything marked as a placeholder (email address, links, week number), add a title, and **Save**.
6. Open **Student View** and confirm the styling survived, every link works, and dates are right.

Adding links to Canvas files and pages

Two ways to connect resource links — both preserve the styling:

- **Visual method:** back in the visual editor, highlight the resource text (e.g., “Chapter 7 Quick Reference Guide”), click the **Insert Link** (chain) icon, and paste the Canvas file URL.
- **Direct method (faster once comfortable):** stay in the HTML editor and replace each placeholder:
`href="[canvas link]" → href="https://yourschool.instructure.com/..."`

TIP Ask the AI to mark every placeholder loudly — [CANVAS LINK], [YOUR EMAIL] — so nothing slips through. A pre-post checklist in an HTML comment at the top of the template (see Appendix) catches the rest.

4. Using Images (Banners, Holiday Graphics)

A banner image can make a special-occasion announcement pop, but images are where announcements most often break. Three rules keep them working:

- **Host the image in Canvas.** Upload it to Course Files (or insert via the editor's image tool), then point the `src` at that Canvas URL. A filename like `src="banner.png"` works on your computer but resolves to nothing inside Canvas.
- **Right-size before uploading.** If your announcement is 660px wide, a 1400px-wide, 2.7 MB photo is wasted weight. Resize to about 2× the display width (for sharp retina rendering) and save as a quality-85 JPEG — the same image often drops from megabytes to a few hundred KB with no visible loss. The AI can do this resizing for you if you upload the image to it.
- **Always include alt text** that states what the image says (e.g., `alt="Juneteenth – Celebrate Freedom – June 19"`) so screen-reader users get the same message.

WATCH OUT Base64-embedded images (the picture encoded directly inside the HTML) are tempting because nothing can “break the link,” but they bloat a 2 KB announcement to hundreds of KB and are unreliable in Canvas. Hosting the image in Canvas Files is the dependable path.

5. Accessibility (ADA / WCAG) Is Part of the Job

A beautiful announcement that fails accessibility isn't finished. The good news: the AI can audit its own work — literally ask “Is this announcement ADA compliant?” and then “please correct those items.” Things it will check, and that you should know to look for:

- **Color contrast:** text needs a 4.5:1 contrast ratio against its background (WCAG AA). Light accent colors on colored banners are the usual offenders — darken the text or lighten it toward white until it clears.
- **Descriptive link text:** “Schedule an office hours appointment,” never “click here” or “follow this link.” Screen-reader users often navigate by jumping link to link.
- **No emoji as content:** decorative emoji (■ ■) read out awkwardly or get skipped. Use real text labels (Days / Time / Location) instead.
- **aria-label on action links** (email buttons, booking links) so their purpose is explicit.
- **Semantic structure:** one real heading, real paragraphs, reasonable font sizes (13px+), generous line height (≈ 1.6 – 1.8).
- **Don't rely on color alone:** pair every color-coded element with a text label (an exam alert should say EXAM, not just be yellow).

6. Iterating Like a Designer (Without Being One)

The first draft is a starting point, not a verdict. The most useful moves in the revision loop:

- **React honestly to wording.** “That closing line seems kind of corny” is excellent feedback — the AI will offer tighter alternatives and can ask which direction (short & direct, conversational, strictly professional) sounds like you.
- **Ask for options on structure.** “How could Day One and Day Two become subheaders under a single Coverage header?” invites two or three labeled approaches with trade-offs and a recommendation — pick one instead of guessing.
- **Request small surgical edits** (“remove ‘Want to meet?’”, “change FIRST DAY BACK to DAY ONE”) rather than regenerating from scratch; the rest of the design stays stable.
- **Let the AI push back.** A good assistant will flag a date that doesn't match your course calendar or an image that clashes with your design — treat those flags as free proofreading.

7. From One-Off to Weekly System: Templates

Once an announcement looks right, ask the AI to convert it into a reusable template. A good template has:

- **[PLACEHOLDERS]** in obvious brackets for everything that changes weekly: week number, title, topics, resources.
- **A checklist in an HTML comment** at the top — comments don't render, so your to-do list travels with the file (see Appendix).
- **Annotated variants:** notes for exam weeks (keep the alert box) vs. regular weeks (delete it), odd resource counts (add a filler cell to balance the grid), etc.
- **Static parts left alone:** your email button, footer, office hours block shouldn't need touching most weeks.

Keep one template per course, and let special occasions (holidays, exam weeks, welcome messages) deliberately depart from it — a distinct design signals “this one is different, read it.”

TIP Working across multiple courses or institutions? Reuse the *structure* and swap the *brand*: same header/body/footer skeleton, different school colors and course labels. The AI can re-skin a template in one request.

Quick Troubleshooting Reference

Symptom	Likely cause & fix
Styling disappears after saving	A <style> block or CSS classes were stripped. Ask the AI to convert everything to inline styles (Section 2).
Fonts look different than the preview	External font import was stripped. Switch to Georgia / Arial system stacks.
Image shows a broken icon	The src points to a local filename. Upload the image to Canvas Files and use its Canvas URL.

Announcement loads slowly	Oversized image. Resize to ~2× display width, compress as JPEG.
Layout breaks on phones	@media queries don't survive. Use flex-wrap / grid auto-fit layouts instead.
Links go nowhere	A [placeholder] was never replaced. Search the HTML for “[” before posting.


```

<div style="background:#C05A00;padding:0.35rem 1.1rem;">
  <span style="font-size:11px;letter-spacing:0.1em;
    text-transform:uppercase;color:#ffffff;font-weight:600;
    font-family:Arial,sans-serif;">Day One &mdash; [SECTION #:
    TOPIC]</span>
</div>
<div style="padding:0.85rem 1.1rem;">
  <p style="font-size:14px;color:#2a2825;line-height:1.65;margin:0;
    font-family:Georgia,serif;">[Brief description of Day One.]</p>
</div>

<!-- DAY TWO -->
<div style="background:#C05A00;padding:0.35rem 1.1rem;">
  <span style="font-size:11px;letter-spacing:0.1em;
    text-transform:uppercase;color:#ffffff;font-weight:600;
    font-family:Arial,sans-serif;">Day Two &mdash; [SECTION #:
    TOPIC]</span>
</div>
<div style="padding:0.85rem 1.1rem;">
  <p style="font-size:14px;color:#2a2825;line-height:1.65;margin:0;
    font-family:Georgia,serif;">[Brief description of Day Two.]</p>
</div>
</div>

<!-- RESOURCES: duplicate a row per resource; if the grid ends
    uneven, add an empty filler div to balance it -->
<p style="font-size:13px;letter-spacing:0.08em;text-transform:uppercase;
    color:#12294B;font-weight:600;margin:0 0 0.6rem;
    font-family:Arial,sans-serif;">This Week's Resources</p>
<div style="display:flex;flex-wrap:wrap;gap:10px;margin:0 0 1.2rem;">

  <a href="[CANVAS LINK]" aria-label="Open [RESOURCE NAME] in Canvas"
    style="flex:1 1 180px;display:flex;flex-direction:column;
    align-items:center;gap:8px;padding:14px 10px;background:#ffffff;
    border:1px solid #d4cfc6;border-radius:12px;text-decoration:none;
    text-align:center;">
    <span style="width:36px;height:36px;background:#12294B;
      border-radius:8px;display:flex;align-items:center;
      justify-content:center;font-size:11px;font-weight:700;
      color:#ffffff;font-family:Arial,sans-serif;">[BADGE]</span>
    <span style="font-size:12px;font-family:Georgia,serif;
      font-weight:600;color:#12294B;line-height:1.35;">
      [RESOURCE NAME]</span>
  </a>
  <!-- ...more resource cards... -->

</div>

<!-- OFFICE HOURS -->
<p style="font-size:13px;letter-spacing:0.08em;text-transform:uppercase;
    color:#12294B;font-weight:600;margin:0 0 0.5rem;
    font-family:Arial,sans-serif;">Office Hours</p>

```

```

<p style="font-size:14px;color:#2a2825;line-height:1.7;
margin:0 0 1.2rem;font-family:Georgia,serif;">
  [Days] &middot; [Times] &middot; [Location]. <a href="[BOOKING LINK]"
  aria-label="Schedule an office hours appointment"
  style="color:#a34f00;font-weight:600;">Schedule an appointment.</a>
</p>

<!-- REMINDER -->
<div style="border-left:3px solid #C05A00;background:#ffffff;
border-top:1px solid #d4cfc6;border-right:1px solid #d4cfc6;
border-bottom:1px solid #d4cfc6;border-radius:0 8px 8px 0;
padding:0.85rem 1.1rem;font-size:14px;color:#2a2825;
line-height:1.65;font-family:Georgia,serif;">
  <strong style="color:#12294B;">Questions are always welcome.</strong>
  If anything is unclear or you hit a snag, my inbox is open.
</div>

</div>

<!-- FOOTER -->
<div style="background:#12294B;padding:0.95rem 2.2rem;display:flex;
align-items:center;justify-content:space-between;flex-wrap:wrap;
gap:12px;">
  <span style="font-size:13px;color:#c8daf0;
font-family:Arial,sans-serif;">Have a great week!</span>
  <a href="mailto:[YOUR EMAIL]" aria-label="Email your instructor"
  style="font-size:13px;font-weight:600;color:#ffffff;
background:#a34f00;border:1px solid #c46000;padding:5px 16px;
border-radius:20px;text-decoration:none;
font-family:Arial,sans-serif;">&#9993;&nbsp; Email Me Anytime</a>
</div>

</div>

```

Design notes: line breaks inside a style="..." attribute are legal HTML — the wrapping above is only for print readability. The resource cards use flex-wrap so they reflow on phones without any @media query.

Session Takeaways

1. You don't write the HTML — you **direct** it. Course knowledge in, styled announcement out.
2. Constrain first: inline styles, system fonts, no scripts, no wrappers. Everything else is decoration on this rule.
3. Verify in Student View every time; ask the AI for an accessibility audit at least once per template.
4. Templatize after the first success — the payoff is a weekly announcement in under ten minutes that looks like it took an hour.